

John Unger

Staunton, Virginia 24401 | (540) 435-2452

john.josef.unger@gmail.com | <https://github.com/john-unger> | <https://linkedin.com/in/john-j-unger>

Summary

Highly skilled, dedicated software engineering leader with extensive experience in architecting scalable backend systems, optimizing performance, and enhancing user experiences. Well-versed in backend development, cloud technologies, and system scalability. Strategic, innovative professional who leverages strong technical skills to support projects and drive improvement.

Team Leadership and Mentorship | Technical Communication | Agile and Scrum Methodologies | Backend Architecture | Workflow Automation | Process Improvement | Performance Optimization

Skills

Programming Languages: Java, JavaScript (Node.js), TypeScript, Python, C, SQL, GraphQL, HTML, CSS

Frameworks and Platforms: Spring Boot, Brightspot CMS (Java-based CMS framework), Django, React, RESTful APIs, JSON, XML

Cloud and Infrastructure: AWS (EC2, S3, Lambda, CloudFront, API Gateway, Translate), Docker, Kubernetes, CI/CD pipelines (GitHub Actions, Jenkins)

Databases: PostgreSQL, MySQL, MongoDB, DynamoDB, Redis

Tools and Development Environment: Git, GitHub, Bitbucket, Jira, Confluence, Slack, Postman, IntelliJ IDEA, VS Code, Bash, Shell scripting, npm, yarn

Testing and QA: JUnit, Jest, Cypress (coordination with FE), Mock APIs, UAT workflows, integration testing frameworks

Automation and DevOps Contributions: Custom release automation scripts, UAT branch management, GraphQL schema warmup automation, CI/CD build troubleshooting

Architecture and Design: Microservices architecture, API middleware design, caching strategies, service fallback design, modular and reusable backend templates, API normalization and data aggregation

Other: Localization and translation systems (AWS Translate), data ingestion and publication workflows, cross-team integration between backend, frontend, QA, and product management

Experience

Brightspot, Reston Virginia (Remote)

Senior Software Engineer 2022 - 2025

- Defined backend architecture patterns and API conventions across the Amazon program (often 6+ concurrent projects); delivered shared templates adopted across Shipping & Freight, Jobs, and Design as stable reference implementations.
- Led CMS backend delivery across ~40 custom projects, powering **132 live sites in 2024 (+32% YoY)** and supporting **\$2.9M ARR (+19% YoY)** and **\$3.5M services revenue (+9% YoY)**.
- Wrote design docs/RFCs, reviewed architecture, and set standards across multiple teams.

- Resolved organization-wide build failure that threatened multiple delivery projects, restoring stability and preventing major release delays.
- Served as lead backend engineer for **Amazon Jobs** and **Griffin Media**; primary backend contributor for **Amazon Science**, **Amazon About**, **Buy with Prime**, and additional properties—owning delivery from design through production releases.
- Improved reliability and developer velocity via release/branch/environment automation, UAT branch workflows, GraphQL schema warm-ups, and resolution of an org-wide build failure impacting multiple delivery projects.
- Modernized legacy backend services to reduce technical debt and improve scalability/maintainability across Amazon programs; built secure integrations for analytics, SEO, content automation, translations, and ingestion with strong guardrails and fallbacks.
- Mentored engineers and interns (including an all-intern feature shipped end-to-end); partnered with product/program leadership on scope, prioritization, and resourcing; documented standards so repeatable features ship in hours, not days.

Vistashare LLC, Harrisonburg, Virginia

Application Programmer 2018 - 2021

- Built features with Django and RESTful APIs; refactored legacy flows and optimized queries to reduce load times by **~60%**.
- Developed and maintained an automated end-to-end Selenium testing framework for parallel/distributed runs.
- Led functional design sessions to improve UI/UX and translate business requirements into technical solutions.

Selected Projects

- **Amazon Jobs @ Brightspot**
Tech lead; migrated to Brightspot while preserving SEO/feature parity and improving reliability, and built an Ownership Group model for delegated permissions/workflows across global teams.
- **Griffin Media @ Brightspot**
Lead backend, started and went live in 2025; built custom Weather API middleware with failover + caching, election ingestion, Whiz app provider, and custom live video provider integration.
- **Amazon Buy with Prime @ Brightspot**
Built AI-assisted backend services integrated with internal ML APIs and existing Java/Python systems, with strict guardrails and fallbacks to keep workflows reliable even under model/API degradation.

Education

The Master's University, Santa Clarita, California

Master of Business Administration (MBA) — Graduated 2023

James Madison University, Harrisonburg, Virginia

Bachelor of Science, Computer Science, Minor in Mathematics — Graduated 2017